Ford Motor Company

James P. Vondale, Director
Automotive Safety Office
Environmental & Safety Engineering

August 8, 2001

Mr. Kenneth N. Weinstein
Associate Administrator for Safety Assurance
National Highway Traffic Safety Administration
400 Seventh Street, S.W.
Washington, D.C. 20590

Dear Mr. Weinstein:

Re: Ford Recall No. 01S25 -- 1999-2001 Model Year Windstar for Windshield Wiper Motor Cover Replacement

Summary

- Ford Action -- Ford is conducting a voluntary safety recall to replace wiper motor cover assemblies on certain 1999/2001 model year Ford Windstar vehicles. These vehicles were built from April 16, 1998 through June 2, 2001.

- Number of Vehicles Involved -- Approximately 777,742 vehicles (approximately 598,256 in the U.S., 135,132 in Canada, and 32,648 in Mexico).

- Effect on Vehicle Operation -- The condition could result in loss of intermittent or park wiper function, complete loss of wiper function, unintended wiper operation and, potentially, melting of the wiper motor cover that could result in smoke and/or fire.

- Service Procedure -- Dealers will install a new wiper motor gear case cover that is more resistant to water entry.

Attached is the detailed information required by the applicable portions of 49 CFR Part 573 -- Defect and Non-Compliance Information Report.

Sincerely,

for James P. Vondale

Attachment
01S25 5d/rjw/ae

ATTACHMENT

49 CFR Part 573 – DEFECT INFORMATION REPORT
01S25 -- 1999-2001 MODEL YEAR WINDSTAR
WINDSHIELD WIPER MOTOR COVER REPLACEMENT

Pursuant to Part 573 of Title 49 of the Code of Federal Regulations, Defect and Noncompliance Reports, Ford Motor Company submits the following information concerning a safety recall action that it is voluntarily initiating.

573.5 (c) (2) -- Potentially Affected Vehicles

Certain 1999-2001 model year Ford Windstar vehicles built at the Oakville Assembly Plant from April 16, 1998 through June 2, 2001.

Because these vehicles are not produced in VIN order, information as to the applicability of this action to specific vehicles can best be obtained by either calling Ford's toll-free line (1-800-392-3673) or contacting a local Ford dealer, who can obtain specific information regarding the vehicles from the Ford On-line Automotive Service Information System (OASIS) database.

573.5 (c) (3) -- Estimated Population of Vehicles Potentially Affected

Approximately 598,256 vehicles.

573.5 (c) (4) -- Estimated Percentage of Affected Vehicles with the Defect Condition

Unknown.

573.5 (c) (5) -- Description of the Defect

Contaminants such as water, salt, and windshield washer solution may enter the wiper motor cover assembly through pinholes on the exterior of the cover that are used in the molding process. In addition, on certain of the vehicles built between February 2000 and August 2000, a switch located in the plastic cover of the wiper motor gear case may malfunction and overheat. Either of these conditions may potentially result in loss of intermittent wiper function, loss of wiper park function, complete loss of wiper function, smoke or, potentially, ignition of the plastic cover material. Contaminant entry may also result in unintended wiper motor operation. Switch malfunction is most likely to occur when the intermittent setting of the wipers is being used, or when snow or ice obstructs the blades from returning to the "parked" position at the bottom of the windshield.

As of June 27, 2001, Ford is aware of 73 reports of thermal damage to the wiper motor cover. Approximately ten of the reports allege that a fire occurred in the wiper motor. None of the reports indicate that the fire progressed beyond the cowl area or that the fire entered the passenger compartment. None of the reports allege that an accident or injury occurred.

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573.5 (c) (6) -- Chronology of Events

A Ford dealership reported a fire in a wiper motor to the wiper motor supplier on December 15, 2000. The supplier began retrieving wiper motors from dealers on January 8, 2001. Ford began investigating this condition on January 23, 2001. On March 3, 2001, it was reported that Windstar customers outside of the suspect time period for the park switch disc concern that is the subject of safety recall 01S24 were reporting similar concerns. After a review of field return parts, an extensive Design of Experiments Test Program was conducted during the spring of 2001 to confirm the root cause of the Windstar concerns. This testing confirmed that motors with a revised park switch disc incorporated in production at the supplier during the period from February 10, 2000 through June 26, 2000 are potentially involved as well as all other 1999-2001 model year Windstars built before June 2, 2001. These vehicles, which have the wiper motor wired to a "hot all the time" battery feed, have unsealed wiper motor cover pinholes and a specific vehicle configuration that can allow the entry of contaminants into the motor. The contaminants can lead to the formation of a carbon track between the power and ground terminals.

573.5 (c) (8) -- Service Program

Owners of record of affected vehicles will be notified by first class mail to return vehicles to dealers for installation of a new wiper motor gear case cover with sealed cover assembly pinholes. In the case of vehicles built between February 2000 and August 2000, the new cover will also contain a more robust park switch disc than the original cover. There will be no charge to owners for this service. In addition, owners will be advised that they can minimize risk prior to the recall service being performed by not using the intermittent mode and by clearing any snow, ice or other obstruction that can prevent the wipers from reaching the park position at the base of the windshield.

573.5 (c) (9) -- Press Statement and Dealer/Owner Letters

Ford does not plan to make a public statement concerning this action. Ford currently plans to begin notifying owners on or about the week of August 13, 2001.

573.5 (c) (11) -- Recall Number

Ford has assigned recall number 01S25 to this action.